knew the Polish and Russian workers weren't allowed to move around freely. Usually an armed soldier escorted them in groups back and forth from the barracks to the factory; all other times they required a special pass to be on the street on their own. It was part of the policy of keeping them strictly segregated from the German population.

The Meister returned with a pass. "Go on," he said, impatient for Maria to be gone now that she posed a potential threat to others.

Unsteady on her feet, Maria struggled to make her way down the stairs. Léa held her up, fearing she might faint. Outside, the sun shone bright on the sidewalk, blinding her eyes. A warm wind came off the hills, carrying the scent of pine in the air. The wind had an eerie howl like wolves in the night. A group of soldiers smoking outside a café eyed Léa suspiciously. She squared her shoulders, pulling Maria along, confident she had the pass in case they stopped and questioned her. She was grateful the sick bay wasn't far because by the time she reached it, her arms burned from Maria's weight.

Josef saw her at the door and immediately went to help. "What happened?"

"I don't know. Maria sits next to me on the assembly line. She's burning up with fever. The Meister eventually allowed me to bring her here."

Josef went to Maria's other side, releasing the pressure on Léa's arms. "I've got one empty bed," he said, lifting Maria gently in his arms and carrying her to the far corner. As Léa watched him place her on the bed, she was grateful that Josef treated Maria like he would anyone. There was a warmth to him that bathed the room in light.

He felt Maria's forehead and neck. "Let me get the thermometer."

While he went to his office, Maria turned restlessly in the bed. "Where is he?"

"Who?" Léa asked.

"Tomasz."

"Is he a friend?"

Maria's head swiveled left and right as she repeated, "Tomasz, Tomasz."

Josef returned and slipped the thermometer under Maria's tongue. "Hold her head steady until there's a temperature reading."

Léa nodded. "Hush, Maria, Tomasz is coming, be still." Placing her hands on either side of Maria's face, she felt the heat on her skin.